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THA 152: Introduction to Media Arts - Radio, Television and Film Basics

How a media production is actually put together

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

This pack explains the production chain for radio, television and film, the roles in a production team, and the basic grammar of shot sizes and sound. It is the foundation for THA 215, THA 252 and THA 324, so treat it as a map rather than a list of definitions.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Describe pre-production, production and post-production stages.
- Identify the roles in a media production team and what each owns.
- Use shot sizes, camera angles and transitions accurately.
- Explain how radio differs from television and film in production logic.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The production chain

Every production, from a radio jingle to a feature film, moves through three phases.

- Pre-production: idea, script, budget, schedule, crew, location and permissions.
- Production: shooting or recording, with continuity and safety management.
- Post-production: editing, sound, colour, graphics and delivery.
- Radio compresses the chain: script, record, edit, broadcast.
- Failures in pre-production surface as chaos on set.
- Keep a paper trail: scripts, schedules, release forms and logs.

Roles and responsibilities

Credit correctly and know who decides what.

- Producer: money, logistics and overall delivery.
- Director: interpretation and creative decisions.
- Scriptwriter: structure and dialogue.
- Cinematographer or camera operator: image and lighting.
- Sound recordist and designer: dialogue, effects and mix.
- Editor: rhythm, continuity and final structure.

> **Say what you own**
> In group projects, write down who owns which deliverable. Ambiguity is the main cause of 'I did everything' disputes.

Visual grammar and sound

Learn the vocabulary before you analyse a film.

- Shot sizes: extreme wide, wide, medium, close-up, extreme close-up.
- Angles: eye level, high, low, Dutch tilt.
- Movement: pan, tilt, dolly, handheld, crane.
- Transitions: cut, dissolve, fade, wipe.
- Sound: diegetic (inside the story world) and non-diegetic (score, narration).
- Continuity: eyeline, screen direction and the 180-degree rule.

Three media, three production logics

Radio, television and film share equipment and vocabulary but organise production differently. Radio has no image, so it must build place, character and action through voice, effects and silence; a listener cannot re-read a sentence, which is why radio writing repeats key information and keeps sentences short.

Television is usually produced against time and in formats: a package with a presenter link, an interview with cutaways, a magazine segment with a fixed duration. The grammar is continuity-based, and the constraint is that the audience may join at any moment, so context must be re-established regularly.

Film is the most controllable and the most expensive per minute. Coverage is shot out of order, so continuity and logging matter more than in the other two, and the story is finally built in the edit. Understanding which logic you are working in prevents the common student error of shooting a film as if it were a recorded stage play.

Grammar you must be able to name